A New Heaven and a New Earth: Orthodox Christian Insights from Theology, Spirituality, and the Sacraments

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Theological and Historical Context

Contributing to the ecumenical statement by the National Council of Churches on the environment, published in the form of an open letter in 2005 and entitled "God's Earth is Sacred: An Open Letter to Church and Society in the United States" (http://www/nccusa.org/news.14.02.05theologicalstatement.html), was a natural response for me as an Orthodox theologian. Ecumenical Patriarch Bartholomew has long assumed an active leadership in this field, placing ecological issues at the center of his ministry. This article examines some of his initiatives, while exploring some of the biblical and theological insights that continue to shape his ecological vision. It also presents a spiritual and sacramental interpretation of the "guiding norms for church and society" proposed by the open letter of the NCCUSA, particularly the affirmation of justice and humility, generosity and frugality, solidarity and compassion.

Setting the Scene

In considering the theological foundation for an ecological consciousness, I sometimes find it useful to journey back to the story of creation. Whenever we think of the Genesis account of creation, we tend to ignore our connection to the environment. Perhaps it is our natural reaction—or perhaps it is a sign of arrogance—but we often overemphasize our creation "in the image of God" (Gen. 1:26) and overlook our creation from "the dust of the ground" (Gen. 2:7). Yet our "heavenliness" should not overshadow our "earthliness."

Most people forget that we human beings did not even get a day to ourselves in Genesis; we shared the sixth day with the creeping and crawling things of the world (Gen. 1:24–26). There is a binding unity and continuity that we share with all of God's creation; it is helpful to recall this truth.

Of course, in more recent years we have been painfully reminded of this truth when we learn of the extinction of flora and fauna, witness soil degradation and forest clearance, and suffer from the effects of air and water pollution. However, our urgent concern for the environment does not result from any superficial threat or even some sentimental romanticism. Rather, it arises from our effort to honor and dignify God's creation. It is a way of paying attention to "the mourning of the land" (Hosea 41:3) and "the groaning of creation" (Rom. 8:22).

This is the reason why the Ecumenical Patriarchate has organized, among other initiatives, a number of international and interdisciplinary symposia over the last decade: ones in the Aegean Sea (1995) and the Black Sea (1997), along the Danube River (1999) and in the Adriatic Sea (2002), in the Baltic Sea (2003), on the Amazon River (2006), and on the Mississippi River (2009). Like the air that we breathe, water is a source of life; if defiled, the very essence of our existence is threatened. Tragically, however, we appear to be caught up in selfish lifestyles that repeatedly ignore the constraints of nature, constraints neither deniable nor negotiable. There will be some things that we learn about our planet's capacity for survival that we will discover only when things are beyond the point of no return.

Initiatives and Activities of the Ecumenical Patriarchate

The environmental initiatives of the Ecumenical Patriarchate date back to the mid-1980s with the third session of the Pre-Synodal Pan-Orthodox Conference held in Chambésy (October 28–November 6, 1986). Representatives at this meeting expressed concern for the abuse of the natural environment, especially as this appears in more affluent Western societies. The meeting also underlined the harm of war, racism, and inequality on human societies and the environment. The emphasis was on leaving a better world for future generations. Several inter-Orthodox meetings followed on the subject of "Justice, Peace, and the Integrity of Creation": the first of three consultations was held in Sofia, Bulgaria (1987). A third inter-Orthodox consultation was held in Minsk, Belarus (1989), while an environmental program was also piloted in Ormylia, Greece (1990).

The second—and perhaps most significant—of these consultations was held in Patmos, Greece (1988), to mark the nine-hundredth anniversary of the historic Monastery of St. John the Theologian. The then Ecumenical

Patriarch, Dimitrios, assigned Metropolitan John (Zizioulas) of Pergamon as Patriarchal representative to this conference, entitled "Revelation and the Future of Humanity" and organized jointly by the Patriarchate and the Greek Ministry of Cultural Affairs in cooperation with the local civil authorities. One of the primary recommendations of this conference was that the Ecumenical Patriarchate should designate one day each year for the protection of the natural environment. This conference proved a catalyst for subsequent Patriarchal initiatives on the environment.

In 1989, Patriarch Dimitrios, the immediate predecessor of Patriarch Bartholomew, his closest adviser, published the first encyclical letter on the environment. Dimitrios was known for his meekness, and it was fitting that during his tenure the worldwide Orthodox Church was invited to dedicate a day of prayer for the protection of the environment, which human beings have treated so harshly. This encyclical, proclaimed on the occasion of the first day of the new ecclesiastical calendar, formally established September 1 as a day for all Orthodox Christians within the jurisdiction of the Ecumenical Patriarchate to offer prayers for the preservation of the natural creation. A similar encyclical is published annually on the first day of September.

In 1990, the foremost hymnographer on Mount Athos, Monk Gerasimos Mikrayiannanites, was commissioned by the Ecumenical Patriarchate to compose a service of supplication for the environment. The Orthodox Church has traditionally prayed for the environment. Whereas, however, in the past, Orthodox faithful prayed to be delivered from natural calamities, the Ecumenical Patriarch now called Orthodox Christians to pray that the planet may be delivered from the abusive and destructive acts of human beings.

A month after his election in 1991, the present Ecumenical Patriarch, Bartholomew, convened an ecological gathering entitled "Living in the Creation of the Lord." That convention on the island of Crete was officially opened by Prince Philip, the Duke of Edinburgh and International Chairman of the WWF. In the following year, Patriarch Bartholomew called an unprecedented meeting of all Orthodox Patriarchs and Primates in Istanbul, submitting a historical expression of unity in theological vision and pastoral concern. The Ecumenical Patriarch again introduced the topic of the protection of the natural environment, inviting all the Orthodox leaders to inform their churches about the critical significance of this issue for our times. The official Message of the Orthodox Primates endorsed September 1 as a day of pan-Orthodox prayer for the environment.

In the summer of 1992, the Duke of Edinburgh visited the Ecumenical Patriarchate for an environmental convocation at the Theological School of

Halki. In November 1993, the Ecumenical Patriarch returned the visit, meeting with the Duke at Buckingham Palace, where they sealed a friendship of common purpose and active cooperation for the preservation of the environment. In June 1994, an ecological seminar was convened at the historic Theological School of Halki, the first of five successive annual summer seminars on diverse aspects of the environment: "Environment and Religious Education" (June 1994), "Environment and Ethics" (June 1995), "Environment and Communications" (July 1996), "Environment and Justice" (June 1997), and "Environment and Poverty" (June 1998). These seminars, the first held at such a level in any Orthodox Church context, were designed to promote environmental awareness and action, engaging leading theologians, environmentalists, scientists, civil servants, and especially students. Participants from all over the world represented the major Christian confessions and world religions.

Convinced that any appreciation of the environmental concerns of our times must occur in dialogue with other Christian confessions, other religious faiths, and the scientific disciplines, in 1994 Patriarch Bartholomew established the Religious and Scientific Committee. He was convinced that, as we share the earth, so do we share the responsibility for our pollution of the earth and the obligation to find tangible ways of healing the natural environment. This ecumenical and interdisciplinary committee is chaired by Metropolitan John of Pergamon, formerly a visiting professor of theology at King's College, London, and currently a professor at the University of Thessalonika. To date, as already mentioned, the Religious and Scientific Committee has hosted six international, interdisciplinary, and interreligious symposia to reflect on the fate of the rivers and seas and to force the pace of religious debate on the natural environment. These symposia have gathered leading scientists, environmentalists, and journalists as well as senior policymakers and representatives of the world's main religious faiths in an effort to draw global attention to the plight of the rivers and seas of the world. Once again, participants meet in plenary, workshop, and briefing sessions, hearing a variety of speakers on various environmental and ethical themes. Delegates also visit key environmental sites in the particular region of the symposium.

Orthodox Theology: Three Ways of Perceiving the World

One of the hymns of the Orthodox Church chanted on the Feast of the Epiphany (January 6, marking the Baptism of Jesus Christ in the River Jordan), a feast of renewal and regeneration for the entire world, eloquently

articulates this tragedy: "I have become the defilement of the air, the land, and the water."

How, then, are we to restore within ourselves a sense of wonder before God's creation? Our theology presents us with three helpful ways:

icons (namely, the way we perceive creation);
liturgy (namely, the way we celebrate creation); and
asceticism (namely, the way we respect creation).

The Iconic Vision of Nature

A sense of the holy in nature implies that everything that breathes praises God (Ps. 150:6); the entire world is a "burning bush of God's energies," as Gregory Palamas claimed in the fourteenth century. When our heart is sensitive, then "our eyes are opened to discern the beauty of created things" (Abba Isaac the Syrian, seventh century). Seeing clearly is precisely what icons teach us to do. The world of the icon offers new insights into reality. It reveals the eternal dimension in everything that we experience. Our age, it may be said, is characterized by a sense of self-centeredness toward the natural world, by a lack of awareness of the beyond. We appear to be inexorably trapped within the confines of our individual concerns. We have broken the sacred covenant between our selves and our world.

Well, the icon restores; it reconciles. The icon reminds us of another way of living and offers a corrective to the culture that we have created, which gives value only to the here and now. The icon reveals the inner vision of all, the world as created and as intended by God. Very often, it is said, the first image attempted by an iconographer is that of the Transfiguration of Christ on Mt. Tabor. This is precisely because the iconographer struggles to hold together this world and the next, to transfigure this world in light of the next. For, by disconnecting this world from heaven, we have in fact desacralized both. The icon articulates with theological conviction our faith in the heavenly kingdom. It does away with any objective distance between this world and the next, between material and spiritual, between body and soul, time and eternity, creation and divinity. The icon speaks in this world the language of the age to come.

This is why the doctrine of the Divine Incarnation is at the very heart of iconography. For, in the icon of Jesus Christ, the uncreated God assumes a creaturely face, a beauty that is "exceeding" (Ps. 44:2), a "beauty that can save the world" (Fyodor Dostoevsky). And in Orthodox icons, faces—whether of Christ or of the saints—are always frontal; two eyes always gaze

back at the beholder. The heart becomes—as the desert father would describe it in the fourth century—"all eyes," eternally receptive of divine grace. Christ is in our midst, here, Emmanuel (Matt. 1:23). Profile signifies sin; it implies a rupture in communication. "I see" means that "I am seen," which in turn means that I am in communion. This is the powerful experience of the invisible and the immortal, a passing over—a Passover, or *Pascha*—to another way of seeing and "a different way of living," as our Easter hymns proclaim.

Indeed, the entire world is an icon, a door opening up to this new reality. Everything in this world becomes a seed. "Nothing is a vacuum in the face of God," wrote Irenaeus of Lyons in the wake of the apostolic era; "everything is a sign of God." Thus, in icons, rivers have a human form; so, too, do the sun and the moon and the stars and the waters. All of them assume human faces; all of them acquire a personal dimension—just like people; just like God.

The Liturgy of Nature

What an icon does with matter, the liturgy does with time. If we are guilty of relentless waste, it is perhaps because we have lost the spirit of worship. We are no longer respectful pilgrims on this earth; we have been reduced to mere tourists. Our original sin lies in our prideful refusal to receive the world as a sacrament of communion.

By liturgical, however, I do not mean ritual. I mean dynamic movement. This world is a never-ending movement toward the kingdom. It is profoundly and intimately related to the heavenly kingdom. This means that what we do on earth matters for what we believe about heaven. The way we relate to other people on earth reflects the way we pray to God in heaven. And, by extension, we respond to nature with the same sensitivity and the same tenderness with which we respond to human beings. We have learned not to treat people like things, because they are created "in the image of God." We must now learn not to treat even things like mere things, because they contain the very trace of God.

Liturgy, then, is precisely a commemoration of this innate connection between God and people and things. It is a celebration of the sense of communion; it is a dance of life. When we recognize this interdependence of all persons and all things—this "cosmic liturgy," as Maximus the Confessor described it in the seventh century—then we will begin to resolve the environmental crisis. For, then we will have acquired, as St. Isaac the Syrian noted in the same century, "A merciful heart burning with love for

all of creation—for humans, birds, beasts, and demons—for all God's creatures."

The world in its entirety comprises an integral part of the liturgy. God is praised by trees and birds, glorified by the stars and moon (Ps. 18:2), worshiped by sea and sand. There is a dimension of art and music in the world. This means, however, that whenever we reduce our spirituality to ourselves and our own interests, we forget that the liturgy implores God for the renewal of the whole polluted cosmos. And whenever we narrow life to our own concerns and desires, we neglect our vocation to raise creation into the kingdom.

The Way of the Ascetics

Of course, this world does not always feel or even look like heaven; a quick glance at the suffering inflicted through wars is sufficient to bring us to our senses. Nonetheless, St. Paul writes, "Through Christ, God was pleased to reconcile to himself all things, whether on earth or in heaven, by making peace through the blood of his cross" (Col. 1:20). Reference to "the blood of the cross" is a clear indication of the cost involved. There is a price to pay for our wasting. Only a spirit of asceticism can lead to a spirit of gratitude and love, to the rediscovery of wonder and beauty in our relationship with the world. So the ascetic way is a way of liberation. The ascetic is one who is free, uncontrolled by attitudes that abuse the world, characterized by self-restraint, as well as the ability to say "no" or "enough." The goal of asceticism is moderation, not repression. Its content is positive, not negative: it looks to service, not selfishness; to reconciliation, not renunciation. Without asceticism, none of us is authentically human.

Consider one example of asceticism in our tradition, namely fasting. We fast from dairy and meat products for half the year, almost as if to reconcile one half of the year with the other, secular time with the time of the kingdom. What does fasting imply? To fast is to learn to give and not simply to give up. It is not to deny but, in fact, to offer; it is learning to share, to connect with human beings and the natural world. Fasting means breaking down barriers with my neighbor and my world: recognizing in others' faces, icons, and in the earth the face of God. Ultimately, to fast is to love, to see clearly, to restore the original beauty of the world. To fast is to move away from what I want to what the world needs. It is to liberate creation from control and compulsion. Fasting is to value everything for itself and not simply for ourselves. It is to be filled with a sense of goodness, of God-liness. It is to see all things in God and God in all things.

Orthodox Practice: Three Models of Caring for the Earth

Now, if our ecological prayer is to move from the distant periphery of an abstract theology to the center stage of practical living, if our spirituality is to become "incarnate," then there are three complementary models that are proposed—and have been tested—by the Orthodox tradition.

The Biblical Model

According to this model, the Church is called to be in solidarity with the weakest parts of the Body of Christ. It must stand for the most vulnerable, the helpless or voiceless elements of this world, which according to St. Paul "groan in travail, awaiting their liberation from the children of God" (Rom. 8:22). This implies a kind of cosmic "liberation theology": "One member cannot say to another, 'I have no need of you.' On the contrary, those members that seem to be weaker are indispensable . . . and our less respectable members are treated with great respect" (1 Cor. 12:20–25).

The earth, too, is a member of our body, a part of our flesh, inseparable from our history and our destiny. In the same way as the God of Israel once heard the cry of the poor and the oppressed (Ex. 3 and Jonah 4), God also hears the silent cry of the earth. This is the biblical covenant, God's promise to the people of Israel: God listens to the world; God attends to the world; God tends to the smallest details of this earth.

The Ascetic Model

In the second model, we might think of the three R's of the ascetic life: renunciation, repentance, and responsibility.

Renunciation is an ancient response—indeed, it is pre-Christian; the ancient Greek philosophers recommended a simple lifestyle. It is also a universal response—indeed, it is even non-Christian; Aboriginal and Indian peoples know this very well. As we have seen, renunciation is a way of learning to share. Therefore, it has social consequences; it reminds us to use material goods respectfully. Renunciation is about living simply and about simply living.

Repentance is a return to a God-given life "according to nature," as the Church Fathers would say. In repentance, we confess that we have sinned—the open letter by the National Council of Churches cites the definition by His All-Holiness Ecumenical Patriarch Bartholomew of the abuse of the natural environment as sin. Moreover, in all humility, we must confess that

we do not share, that we are self-centered, that we in fact abuse the resources of the earth. Through repentance, we recognize that we have fallen short of our vocation "to serve and preserve the earth" (Gen. 2:15).

Responsibility is our challenge, our choice. Having renounced whatever clutters our mind and our life, and after repenting of our wastefulness, we can direct our lives in love and reverence toward creation and Creator.

The Sacramental Model

And—at least in the Orthodox Christian practice—we achieve this through the sacraments, which have an undeniable and indelible environmental seal. Unfortunately, the sacraments are often reduced to ritual observances. Yet communion is much more than a way of pious inspiration or individual reward. It is the imperative to share. It is crucial, then, that we recall the sacramental dimension of the world, recognizing that nothing is merely secular or profane. Everything is created by God and embraced by God. God is—and is within—the very constitution of our world. If God were withdrawn from the world, the world would collapse. Before Vespers each evening, we recite the Ninth Hour and recall our vocation to realize the presence of God "at every hour and every moment, both in heaven and on earth, indeed in all places of his dominion" (Ps. 103:22). Such is the depth of a sacramental worldview.

Orthodox Christians in fact prefer to speak of "mystery" rather than "sacrament," the latter of which tends to imply the acquisition of something "objective." Traditionally, it is said that there are seven mysteries or sacraments. Yet this categorization is neither completely true nor always helpful. The Orthodox Church has never limited itself to seven sacraments, preferring to speak of every moment and aspect of life as being sacramental—from birth through death. Indeed, the funeral service was once also classified as a sacrament in Orthodox liturgical practice. So the sacraments do not work in some magical manner; rather, they function "mystically," silently permeating the hearts and lives of those who choose to be open to the possibility of encounter with God—like the flow of blood in the human body.

Let us consider the mysteries.

In the sacramental way, Baptism becomes more than merely a formal initiation to some exclusive or closed community. Baptism is a re-creation of humanity and the world in the light of Christ. Through the water of Baptism, we are immersed into the death and resurrection of Christ (Rom. 14:8), being "planted together" (Rom. 6:5) forever with Christ. In a world where water is so carelessly wasted and polluted, the sacrament of Baptism high-

lights the profound connection between the Spirit of God brooding over "the face of the world," as in the first moments of Genesis, and the entire universe. The living water of the living God is able to renew and sanctify all of creation.

The sacrament of Chrismation is more than a confirmation of our personal membership in the Body of Christ. It recognizes "the seal of the gift of the Holy Spirit" in all human beings, in all corners of the world, and in all elements of the universe. We are, therefore, called to recognize the face of God in the face of each person as well as in the face of the natural world. The word "chrismation" derives from the Greek *chrisma*, which means anointing; the "anointed one" is the "Christ" or the "Messiah" (in Hebrew). Our goal is to be "in Christ" and Christ-like, anointing and healing the entire world.

The sacrament of the Eucharist is of course pregnant with endless possibilities for deepening communion. It is an invitation to conform to the Body of Christ. The Eucharist is not a spiritual reward for rigorous ascetic discipline. Rather, it challenges individuals and communities to work for a just society where basic food and water are plentiful for all and where everyone has enough.

The sacrament of Confession provides more than simply an opportunity to express remorse for the removal of guilt. Forgiveness provides the grace and space "for giving," for sharing. It focuses attention on others and on God's creation—not only on ourselves. It is a way of reintegration into the Body of Christ. But it is also a reintegration into the body of society and the world.

In Marriage, a couple is invited to experience and celebrate communion despite the pain of brokenness, separation, and isolation. How unfortunate it is that this sacrament has been conveniently reduced to a social contract, somehow introducing a romanticized urban lifestyle in Western society. In its spiritual sense, marriage is primarily the experience of the cross, the other side of the coin that we call ascesis. As such, it is the desire for unity between Creator and creation, God and humanity, body and soul, time and eternity, heaven and earth.

Holy Unction is a healing sacrament. In the Orthodox practice, it is celebrated throughout life as the outpouring of "the oil of gladness" on the scars of the soul and the wounds of the world. It aims at healing the breach or brokenness between body and soul, mending the shattered parts of the heart and the earth while reconciling heaven with all of God's creation.

Finally, the sacrament of Ordination is not a formal declaration of the exclusive rights granted to the hierarchy. Priesthood is the royal vocation of all people. Through ordination, the Body of Christ receives new expression and renewed vitality. The whole world becomes a cathedral; every person is

ordained for the kingdom, and no place is unhallowed. When we discern the presence of God in everyone and in every place, then we can rejoice and celebrate the fullness of life.

Conclusion

The ultimate image of sacramental communion in the Orthodox Church is represented in color through the icon depicting the hospitality of Abraham and Sarah welcoming three strangers in the desert of Palestine. It is an icon of the communion between the three persons of the Trinity. The story is related in Genesis 18 of Abraham sitting under the oak trees of Mamre: "The Lord appeared to Abraham by the oaks of Mamre, as he sat at the entrance of his tent in the heat of the day" (Gen. 18:1). If we pay close attention to the biblical narrative, not only do the oaks provide refreshing shade for the Patriarch of Israel, but they are the occasion for divine revelation. By analogy, not only do the trees of the world provide sustenance for humankind in diverse ways, but they reflect the very presence of God. Cutting them down implies eliminating the divine presence from our lives. Indeed, the Hebrew interpretation of this text implies that the oak trees themselves—just as the visitors who appeared at the same time—actually reveal God. Indeed, it was not until Abraham recognized the presence of God in the trees (namely, in creation, or *adamah*) that he was also able to recognize God in his visitors (namely, in human beings, or *adam*). Creation, just like the human beings who appeared in the form of angels, is itself the manifestation of God in the world.

The crisis that we are facing in our world is not primarily ecological. It is a crisis concerning the way we envisage or imagine the world. We are treating our planet in an inhuman, godless manner precisely because we fail to see it as a gift inherited from above; it is our obligation to receive, respect, and in turn hand on this gift to future generations. Therefore, before we can effectively deal with problems of our environment, we must change the way we perceive the world. Otherwise, we are simply dealing with symptoms, not with their causes. We require a new worldview if we are to desire "a new heaven and a new earth" (Rev. 21:1). This is our calling; indeed, this is God's command. It would be advisable to hear and heed it now. As His All-Holiness Ecumenical Patriarch Bartholomew declared jointly with the late Pope John Paul II in Venice in 2002: "It is not too late. God's world has incredible healing powers. Within a single generation, we could steer the earth toward our children's future. Let that generation start now, with God's help and blessing."